WHAT IS AN ILEOSTOMY?

An ileostomy is a surgically created opening into the small intestine – through the abdomen. The purpose of an ileostomy is to allow stool to bypass the colon.
Because of an injury or disease – such as ulcerative colitis or chron's disease – the colon (the large bowel) may be surgically removed, along with the rectum and anus. The colon's main purpose is to absorb water and store stool. Your body can continue to function without a colon.
When a person has an ileostomy, stool is no longer eliminated through the anus, instead, stool is eliminated through the ileostomy, and an ileostomy does not have sphincter muscles, so a person who has an ileostomy has no voluntary control over bowel movements. Instead, the person wears a disposable pouch to collect the stool.
To construct an ileostomy, the surgeon brings part of the small intestine (ileum) through the abdominal wall. This new opening on the person's abdomen is called a stoma. The skin around the stoma is called the peristomal skin. Each person's stoma is unique. Chances are your stoma will look different from another person's stoma.
There are no nerve endings in the stoma, so the stoma is not painful. The stoma is always red to pinkish in colour and moist. The stoma may also bleed easily. This type of minor, temporary bleeding is normal. However if discharge from stoma is bloody, you should contact your doctor.

STOOL FROM AN ILEOSTOMY

Remember the stool from an ileostomy comes directly from the small intestine, so the stool contains digestive enzymes that can be very irritating to the skin. Because of that the flange you wear must fit well around the stoma.

ODOUR

Odour is a major concern for people with an ileostomy, today; ileostomy pouches are made with odour barrier film, so odour from the stool is contained inside the pouch. If the pouch is clean, and is applied properly, you should notice odour only when you are emptying or changing your pouch. If you notice odour at any other time, check the pouch seal for leakage. Ileostomy pouches are open on one end, so they can be emptied as needed. You should empty your pouch when it is necessary and convenient. Regular emptying can help to avoid a bulge from a pouch that is too full.

Sometimes certain foods can affect the odour of stool. If odour is a concern for you, you may want to avoid foods that increase odour. (Read section on diet)

Gas

The amount of gas that a person's system generates depends on the individual.
Sometimes, intestinal gas can be the result of swallowing air. Drinking carbonated beverages, smoking, chewing gum, and chewing with your mouth open can all increase the amount of air you swallow.
Gas can also be caused by the foods you eat. If gas is a problem for you, you may want to avoid certain gas forming foods. (Read section on diet.)

DIET

Having an ileostomy does not mean you have to be on a special diet. Always eat a balanced diet. Eat slowly and chew your food well. To avoid becoming dehydrated, you should drink plenty of water, juice or other liquids each day
There are those foods that can cause odour or gas in your system. If this is a concern for you, you may want to eat those foods in moderation. Also, it is better to avoid foods that can cause blockages in your bowel, foods that will not pass through the stoma.

Foods that may increase odour: asparagus, broccoli, Brussels' sprouts cabbage, cauliflower, eggs, fish, garlic, onions and spices.

Foods that may increase gas: beans, beer, broccoli, Brussels' sprouts, cabbage, carbonated beverages, cauliflower, corn, cucumbers, mushrooms, peas and spinach.

Foods that can cause intestinal blockage: Chinese vegetables, coconut, nuts, peanuts, popcorn, foods with non digestable peels and cole slaw.

DIARRHOEA

For anyone, diarrhoea can be caused by an illness or by a variety of reasons. With an ileostomy, you can still get diarrhoea.
If you get diarrhoea, there are some foods you can eat that will help to thicken your stools. Avoid foods that may cause loose stools.

Foods that may thicken your stools are: bananas, cheese, marshmallows, noodles, rice, toast and yogurt.

Foods that may cause loose stools are: beer or other alcohol, broccoli, green beans, prunes or prune juice, fresh fruit (except banana) and spinach.

BATHING OR SHOWERING

With an ileostomy, you can shower or bathe just as you did before. Soap and water will not flow into your stoma or hurt your stoma in any way. You may choose to shower or bathe with your pouch on or off – the choice is yours. Because soap residue can sometimes interfere with how well the skin barrier or adhesive sticks to your skin, avoid soap that leaves a residue on your skin.

SKIN CARE

It is very important that the skin around the stoma remain healthy and free from irritation. The peristomal area should look just like the skin elsewhere on your abdomen. To prevent skin irritation you must have a flange that fits properly.
Each time you remove the flange, check the surrounding skin. If you notice any redness or rash you could have irritated skin. Sometimes – but not always- irritated skin is painful. If the problem persists seek medical help.

CLOTHING

People with an ileostomy, worry that the pouch will be visible under their clothing. Some people think they won't be able to wear normal clothes, or that they will have to wear clothes that are too big for them. The fact is you should be able to wear the same type of clothes you wore before your surgery. Today's pouches are so thin and fit so close to the body, chances are no one will know you are wearing a pouch – unless you tell them.

RETURNING TO WORK AND TRAVELLING

After your recovery, you should be able to return to work, or travel just about anywhere. Your ileostomy should not limit you. Always take your own supplies with you when you travel – and always take more than you think you will need. Keep your ostomy products with you in your hand luggage. Never leave ostomy products in a hot environment, the adhesives can melt. If you take out an insurance make sure that you are well covered because of the ileostomy.

EXERCISE AND SPORTS

An ileostomy should not prevent you from exercising or from being physically active. Other than extremely rough contact sports or very heavy lifting, you should be able to enjoy the same physical activities you enjoyed before your surgery.

SEX AND PERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS

Because ileostomy surgery is a body altering procedure, many people worry about sex and intimacy and about acceptance by their spouse or loved ones. For people who are dating a big concern is how to tell someone about the ileostomy.

It is important to remember that supportive personal relationships can be major sources of healing after any type of surgery. It is also important to let your partner know that sexual activity will not hurt you or your stoma. Ileostomy surgery affects both partners in a relationship and it is something to which both partners must adjust – each in his or her own way. The key, of course, is understanding and communication.

Stoma Care Clinic No. 25454431